Old Museum Frogs Solve a Vanishing Mystery

From: ScienceDaily Most Popular Mined: 2026-11-04 3 min read

For almost 50 years, scientists did not know why frogs started disappearing from a forest in Brazil in the 1970s. Now, frogs kept in a museum have helped solve the mystery.

The main suspect is a deadly disease caused by a tiny **fungus**. The disease spread around the world in the 1970s and 1980s, but scientists only identified the **fungus** in 1999 long after the frogs began to vanish.

A team from the Smithsonian and Pennsylvania State University tested more than 370 frogs that had been **preserved** in museum jars. The frogs were collected in Brazil's Atlantic Forest before and after the disappearances.

None of the frogs collected before 1979 had the disease. But more than half of the frogs collected in the 1980s did. This suggests the **fungus** arrived just as the frog populations **crashed**.

Strangely, the **species** that disappeared most showed no signs of the disease. Scientists think those frogs may have died so fast that few sick ones were ever collected.

Word Treasure

fungus -- A living thing like a mushroom or mold; some fungi can make animals sick.

species -- A group of living things that are the same kind, like one kind of frog.

preserved -- Kept safe for a long time so something does not rot or fall apart.

crashed -- In this story, dropped suddenly -- the frog populations crashed, meaning their numbers fell fast.

Background you need

Some fungi are tiny living things that can make animals sick.

Long ago, scientists kept frogs in museum jars, and those old frogs can still teach us things today.

Testing them showed when a sickness first reached the forest.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists from the Smithsonian and Pennsylvania State University
WHAT: They tested old museum frogs and found a deadly fungus arrived just as frogs were vanishing
WHERE: Brazil's Atlantic Forest
WHY: The fungus spread around the world in the 1970s and 1980s, before scientists even knew it existed

Why it matters

Frogs help keep nature in balance, and solving this mystery can help protect frogs that are still alive today.

Test what you remember

1. What mystery did scientists solve?

- (A) Where frogs sleep
- (B) How frogs sing
- (C) Why frogs are green
- (D) Why frogs started disappearing from a forest in Brazil

2. What is the main suspect?

- (A) A big snake
- (B) A long dry season
- (C) A deadly disease caused by a tiny fungus
- (D) A new road

3. Where were the helpful frogs kept?

- (A) In a museum
- (B) In a zoo
- (C) In a pond
- (D) In a school

4. How many frogs did the team test?

- (A) Three
- (B) Exactly one thousand
- (C) More than 370
- (D) Ten

5. What did tests show about frogs collected before 1979?

- (A) All had the disease
- (B) They were bigger frogs
- (C) None had the disease
- (D) Half had the disease

6. What strange thing did scientists notice?

- (A) The species that disappeared most showed no signs of the disease
- (B) The fungus was helpful
- (C) The frogs could talk
- (D) The museum frogs were still alive

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: A 4: C 5: C 6: A

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):